

Two new bird records for China

Kuo-Lang CHANG¹, Liang CHEN², Jinyu LEI^{3,✉}

¹4F, No. 11, 6 Lane, Fu Kuei ST, Hsin Tien, Taipei, China

²China Daily Press, No. 15 Huixin Dongjie Street, Chaoyang District, Beijing 100029, China

³WWF China Wuhan Office, Room 607, Institute of Geodesy & Geophysics, Chinese Academy of Sciences, Wuchang 430077, China

Abstract Two new bird records for China of the Himalayan Black-lored Tit (*Parus xanthogenys*) and the Nepal Wren-Babbler (*Pnoepyga immaculata*) were established at Zhangmu, a small town in Tibet bordering on Nepal, in two birding trips in 2010, respectively.

Keywords new bird record, Himalayan Black-lored Tit (*Parus xanthogenys*), Nepal Wren-Babbler (*Pnoepyga immaculata*), China

Introduction

In January (K.L. Chang) and May 2010 (J.Y. Lei and L. Chen), we carried out two separate birding trips in the southern Zhangmu, a small town in southern Tibet (27°59'37"N, 85°58'00"E; 1755–2380 m a.s.l.) adjacent to Nepal. We observed birds by binoculars, made photographs and recorded sounds of some significant bird species during these trips. Among the bird species we recorded in these trips, we identified the Himalayan Black-lored Tit (*Parus xanthogenys*) and the Nepal Wren-Babbler (*Pnoepyga immaculata*) which have not been included in any checklist of birds of China (e.g. Cheng, 1987; MacKinnon et al., 2000; Zheng, 2005) and hence they are confirmed as new bird records for China. Here we describe details of these two new bird records.

Himalayan Black-lored Tit (*Parus xanthogenys*)

Two tits with vivid yellow facial patterns were recorded by K.L. Chang on 18 January 2010 and were quickly identified as Himalayan Black-lored Tits according to his previous birding experience of this species in Nepal (Fig. 1). In a subsequent spring trip, J.Y. Lei, L. Chen and four other observers also located and photographed a flock of Himalayan Black-lored Tits ($n > 10$) on the road from Zhangmu to the China-Nepal border checkpoint at an elevation of 1600 m on 12 May and 15 May 2010. This species may be either a common or an uncommon resident at Zhangmu.

The Himalayan Black-lored Tit (Fig. 1) is a large-sized tit, estimated to be about 13 cm in length, with a body size equally large as that of the Great Tit (*Parus major*) and the Yellow-cheeked Tit (*P. spilontus*). It is a yellow-and-black tit, with a broad black line through the middle of its underparts, extending to the breast and throat. The long and pronounced crest, neck and front are also black with yellow cheeks. Black stripes, started from the neck, extend to the lores, constituting a striking facial pattern. The upper parts are olive-green with a few black streaks

Received 8 June 2010; accepted 20 August 2010

✉ Author for correspondence (Jinyu Lei)
E-mail: jyilei@wwfchina.org



Fig. 1 The Himalayan Black-lored Tit (*Parus xanthogenys*) (Photo by Liang Chen)

confined to the scapulars. It resembles the Yellow-cheeked Tit (*P. spilonotus*), probably its closest relative, as well as the other yellow-and-crested tit in the Himalayas, but this latter bird apparently lacks black in its forehead and lores. Females and young birds are reported to be duller in color than males (Grimmett et al., 1999; Rasmussen and Anderton, 2005). The flock we observed may have been a mixture of both males and female-like birds.

This species is a common resident in open tropical forests, secondary forests and edges of dense forests and groves of the Indian subcontinent, from north Pakistan through the Himalayas to eastern Nepal (Grimmett et al., 1999; Rasmussen and Anderton, 2005). Three subspecies were described under the species level, the nominate races *xanthogenys*, *aplonotus* and *travancorensis* (Grimmett et al., 1999; Rasmussen and Anderton, 2005). Based on evidence of morphology and vocalization, Rasmussen and Anderton (2005) proposed that *xanthogenys* and the two other subspecies should be treated as two species: the Himalayan Black-lored Tit (*Parus xanthogenys*) (monotypic) and the India Black-lored Tit (*P. aplonotus*), with subspecies *aplonotus* and *travancorensis*. Gill (2010) adopted this taxonomic treatment in the *IOC World Bird Names*. The location where we

sighted the birds, our field description and morphological characteristics shown in the photographs, explicitly match the diagnosis of the taxon *xanthogenys*. Following Gill (2010), we therefore confirm that our sighting of the Himalayan Black-lored Tit (*P. xanthogenys*) is a new record for this bird species in China.

Nepal Wren-Babbler (*Pnoepyga immaculata*)

On 8 May 2010, near the Zhangmu Hotel we heard a series of high-pitched metallic notes, like “*tsi-tsu-tsi-tsi-tsu-tsi-tsi*”, speeding up at the end and repeating several times. We then recorded its repeating sound and did play-back. The bird responded promptly and was easily lured out, standing at a fallen twig and presenting a full view to us, and was identified as a Nepal Wren-Babbler. It was a typical small, round and tailless Wren-Babbler, about 10 cm long. The bird was uniformly fulvous on its upper and under parts with dense black arrow-shaped streaks on breast and belly. Moreover, the bird did not have eye-brows.

There are three potential wren-babbler species of such a morphological type, sympatrically occur-



Fig. 2 The Nepal Wren-Babbler (*Pnoepyga immaculata*) (Photo by Haitao Li)

ring in the Himalayas: the Scaly-breasted Wren-Babbler (*Pnoepyga albiventer*), the Pygmy Wren-Babbler (*P. pusilla*) and the Nepal Wren-Babbler (*P. immaculata*). Considering the species we observed at Zhangmu, we first ruled out *P. pusilla* by its unspotted wings and tertials (Fig. 2). We are also very familiar with the diagnostic “three-note” song by *P. pusilla*, which we did not hear in this case. With respect to *P. albiventer*, our species apparently lacks spots on its crown, mantle and wing-covers (Fig. 2). We are therefore inclined to infer that the bird is a Nepal Wren-Babbler (*P. immaculata*). This species is reported to have a longer and heavier bill than *P. pusilla* (Grimmett et al., 1999; Rasmussen and Anderton, 2005), but it was almost impossible for us, on the basis of this trait, to make detailed comparisons in these field conditions. Afterwards, we compared our derived song type to a reference song of a putative Nepal Wren-Babbler (available at <http://www.xeno-canto.org/browse.php?query=Nepal+Babbler>) and consolidated our preliminary judgment about the species identification. During the next few days (until 18 May), we repeatedly heard this distinctive song at many other sites between 1800–2200 m elevation around Zhangmu County, indicating that the species might be a fairly common breeder in the region.

The Nepal Wren-Babbler has been neglected as a full species because its song was long thought to be a

variant of the song of the Scaly-breasted Wren-Babbler (*P. albiventer*) (Martens and Eck, 1991). It has lately been realized that birds with this kind of song are morphologically differentiated from the Scaly-breasted Wren-Babbler (unspotted crown, mantle and wing-covers) and hence, the status of this unknown bird species was resolved. The Nepal Wren-Babbler is an endemic resident breeder of the Indian Subcontinent and the Himalayas, from eastern Nepal west to Himachal Pradesh in India. It is commonly found in temperate forests and subtropical or tropical moist montane habitats in undergrowth near streams and rivers (Grimmett et al., 1999; Rasmussen and Anderton, 2005). There are no records of this species in Tibet, China in any published checklist of birds of China, which is presumably due to wrong species identification resulting from neglect of subtle differences between this species and its close relatives.

Although Zhangmu is a small town, it has become a hot birding spot in China since it has already witnessed several new records of bird species for China in recent years, including the Himalayan Bulbuls (*Pycnonotus leucogenys*) (Zhang et al., 2006), Tickell’s Thrush (*Turdus unicolor*) (Yu, 2008) and the Black-chinned Babbler (*Stachyridopsis pyrrhops*) (Dong and Yang, 2010). More new bird species for China are expected to be recorded at this site in the future.

Acknowledgments We thank Yang Liu and Yat-Tung Yu for their constructive comments, which substantially improved an earlier draft. We are grateful to two anonymous reviewers who provided valuable comments on an earlier draft of this manuscript. We also thank Haitao Li, Qin Wang, Li Zhang and Jia Zhong for joining our field expeditions.

References

- Cheng TH. 1987. A Synopsis of the Avifauna of China. Science Press, Beijing. (in Chinese)
- Dong JT, Yang XJ. 2010. A New Record of Bird Species in China: Black-chinned Babbler (*Stachyris pyrrhops*). Zool Res, 3:318–319. (in Chinese)
- Gill F, Donsker D. 2010. IOC World Bird Names (version 2.4). <http://www.worldbirdnames.org>. Accessed 7 June 2010.
- MacKinnon J, Phillipps K, He FQ. 2000. A Field Guide to the Birds of China. Oxford University Press, Oxford.
- Martens J, Eck S. 1991. *Pnoepyga immaculata* n. sp., eine neue bodenbewohnende Timalie aus dem Nepal-Himalaya. J Ornithol, 132: 179–198. (in German)
- Rasmussen PC, Anderton JC. 2005. Birds of South Asia: the Ripley Guide. Lynx Edicions, Barcelona.
- Yu YT. 2008. Tickell's Thrush *Turdus unicolor* at Zhangmu, Tibet Autonomous Region: a new species to China. Fork-tail, 24:133–134.
- Zhang GF, Lee KC, Chiang ML, Cheng HF. 2006. Himalayan Bulbul *Pycnonotus leucogenys*: a species new to China. In: China Ornithological Society (eds) China Bird Report 2005. China Ornithological Society, Beijing, pp 409–412.
- Zheng GM. 2005. A Checklist on the Classification and Distribution of the Birds of China. Science Press, Beijing. (in Chinese)

中国鸟类物种新记录——眼纹黄山雀和尼泊尔鹪鹩

张国郎¹, 陈亮², 雷进宇³

(1 台北县新店市富贵街六巷十一号四楼, 台北; 2 《中国日报》社, 北京, 100029; 3 世界自然基金会(瑞士)北京代表处武汉项目办公室, 武汉, 430077)

摘要: 2010年, 我们在西藏日喀则樟木分别发现眼纹黄山雀 (*Parus xanthogenys*) 和尼泊尔鹪鹩 (*Pnoepyga immaculata*), 皆为中国鸟类物种新记录。

关键词: 鸟种新记录, 眼纹黄山雀 (*Parus xanthogenys*), 尼泊尔鹪鹩 (*Pnoepyga immaculata*), 中国